Readiness diagnostic: the sixteen checks

Each check maps to a concern of accessibility in the FCSM data-quality sense (FCSM 20-04).

Generated by `scripts/sixteen_checks_build.py` from the framework record.

A check is marked Scored when its pass line rests on a published source; four of the sixteen are Scored, read from the instrument's own state and the scoring model rather than typed in.

A check that is not measured always names a reason, and never counts as a fail.

#	Check	What we look at	It passes when	Why it matters	Quality concern^a
1	Data offered as a file a program can read (Scored)	On the agency's data page.	A link on this data page.	OMB memo M-25-05, Phase 2 Implementation of the Evidence Act, requires public data to be readable by programs, and USAFacts' guide says to avoid PDF-only release.	Usable format (find and obtain)
2	The whole dataset in one download (Scored)	On the agency's data page.	This data page links.	The World Wide Web Consortium's data guidance asks that a full dataset come in one request, and OMB memo M-23-22, Delivering a Digital-First Public Experience, urges offering whole datasets for download.	Usable format (find and obtain)
3	The data page is in the site's list of pages (Scored)	The sitemap files at the standard locations on the agency's own site (a sitemap.	Every data page looked at was found listed: a sitemap served on the agency's own site carries the page's address exactly as the diagnostic records it.	OMB memo M-23-22, Delivering a Digital-First Public Experience, asks agencies to publish such lists, in the published standard format.	Find and obtain
4	A published description of the agency's data service	At the data-interface address recorded for the agency in the project's records (read from the agency's own pages or seeded from a named source such as a developer page or a public catalog).	A machine-readable OpenAPI or Swagger description document is served at the data-interface address recorded for this agency.	A World Wide Web Consortium practice asks for service details that programs can read; the required file format is this project's rule.	Understand (metadata)
5	Whether the site's visitor rules let AI tools in	The single robots.txt file at the root of the agency's website.	The host's robots.txt.	OMB memo M-23-22, Delivering a Digital-First Public Experience, tells agencies to use this file so pages can be found; treating certain blocks as failures is this project's rule.	Find and obtain
6	The page labels itself as a dataset	The data page itself.	Every data page looked at carried markup.	A shared labelling scheme used by the major search engines (schema.org) defines these labels, and USAFacts' guide asks for standard metadata.	Metadata (find and obtain)
7	The release date, and a link to the latest release	The data page itself (its structured date markup and the server's last-modified header) and up to three links on the same site that point to the latest version.	Every data page looked at carried a release or modification date in its markup (in the dateModified or datePublished field.	Guidance from the World Wide Web Consortium says a dataset's version should be detectable; requiring the link to work is this project's rule.	Metadata
8	A front door built for programs	A fixed handful of machine addresses this project checks on the agency's site: the recorded API base and its description.	For every data page looked at.	This project's rule: no published standard defines such a starting point yet.	Find and obtain (usable format)
9	The interactive data tool answers honestly	At the one interactive data tool the agency offers.	The direct link came back as a working page carrying at least two thousand characters of text before any script ran.	An internet standard defines a "not found" answer; the minimum amount of readable text is this project's rule.	Usable format
10	What the site states about automated access	At the site's robots.txt file and at the robots meta tags carried on the data page.	This records what the agency declares.	The internet standard for that instructions file says it is not a lock; this records a statement and is not scored.	Find and obtain
11	The site serves what its own rules permit	At the site's robots.txt file and at the data page's web address.	This check is under review and is not scored yet.	Comparing what a site says with what it does is this project's own idea, still under review.	Find and obtain
12	From a data page to the data service, terms, change log and inventory	At one of the agency's data pages, its links and its response headers, and at the recorded locations where each of the four objects was reported to sit.	Every object the agency is shown to publish is either linked from this data page or sits at its published standard address.	A web standard sets an address for listing data services, and OMB memo M-25-05, Phase 2 Implementation of the Evidence Act, fixes where the inventory lives; joining the four is this project's rule.	Find and obtain (metadata)
13	The methods are readable as plain text	The data product page itself.	Every data page that was looked at links to a methodology document served as a web page or plain text.	A published documentation guide asks that methods be reachable by automated visitors; the no-scripts reading is this project's rule.	Understand
14	The product is listed in the agency's data inventory (Scored)	The agency's public data inventory at each location on record for it, its own data.json file.	Every data page that was looked at appears in a record that names its address in a DCAT-US address field.	OMB memo M-25-05, Phase 2 Implementation of the Evidence Act, requires every agency to keep a complete data inventory at that address.	Find and obtain (metadata)
15	The terms of reuse, under a recognised name	The licence field in the data page's markup.	Every data page that was looked at names a licence by a recognised identifier in at least one of those places.	The web's standards body asks for a stated licence; demanding a standard licence identifier is this project's rule.	Metadata
16	A change history a program can follow	Each change-log or release-notes location on record for the agency.	Every data page that was looked at has a change history served as a JSON.	The World Wide Web Consortium asks publishers for a full version history; requiring it in a fixed structured form is this project's rule.	Metadata

^a The concern each check serves in the FCSM Framework for Data Quality (FCSM 20-04), Accessibility dimension, after Webb 2026.

Standard user: anonymous and keyless: it honours robots.txt and holds to the standing rate limit.

API user: the same client registered as any member of the public registers, presenting a key obtained by open registration, a good-faith handshake, not a barrier.